

ADAP Is Welfare-to-Work for Disabled Albertans

How the AISH–ADAP split imports the Income Support employability tiers onto disability income.

The Government of Alberta has presented the Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP) as a new, person-centred program — modern, generous, and shaped by the disability community. This document sets that framing aside and examines the structure underneath it. When the language is stripped away and the architecture is laid bare, ADAP is not a novel disability program. It is the importation of Alberta’s existing welfare-to-work system — the employability-tiering used in the Income Support (Alberta Works) program — onto disability income. The transition of AISH recipients to ADAP re-creates, for people with disabilities, the same sorting-by-employability that has long governed general welfare in this province, including its defining feature: income that is conditional on participation in employment activity.

The architecture Alberta already uses

Alberta’s Income Support program does not treat its recipients as a single group. It sorts every client by employability into two streams: Expected to Work, for those considered employable, and Barriers to Full Employment, for those who cannot work due to chronic health problems or other lasting barriers. Within the Barriers to Full Employment stream sit named sub-types, among them “Medical or Multiple Barriers” — for people unable to work full-time because of a health condition expected to last more than six months — and “Severe Handicap,” for those who meet the AISH definition of disability. The categorization is not fixed. The province’s own policy framework describes it as a dynamic system in which a worker revises a client’s sub-type as that person’s relationship to the labour market changes. Alberta, in other words, already operates a tiered system that ranks recipients by how employable the state considers them — and re-ranks them over time.

The mechanism that defines the employment tier

The defining feature of the employment tier is conditionality. In the Expected to Work category, a recipient is required to follow an employment plan. If they do not follow through on that plan, or on other expectations placed on them, a worker can deny or end their benefits. This is the engine of welfare-to-work: assistance is not a stable floor but a conditional payment, contingent on the recipient’s ongoing participation in employment activity. When participation does not happen — for any reason, including inability — it is processed administratively as non-compliance. And non-compliance is income loss. This is the crucial point for what follows, because it is the mechanism the disability program is now being rebuilt around.

How ADAP maps onto the model

ADAP is the employment-activation tier, applied to disability income. The government’s own transition correspondence describes the apparatus plainly: a service navigator who contacts the recipient to begin employment-services participation, alongside career planning, supported job placements, and employment income exemptions designed to reward earnings. At the same time, AISH is repositioned as the narrow exception. To remain on — or return to — AISH, a person must now establish, through the new Disability Income Assistance application, a severe disability that permanently prevents employment. The bulk transfer of existing AISH recipients into ADAP moves the default population into the employment track; AISH becomes the category a person must affirmatively re-qualify for, on the government’s terms and on the government’s timetable. That is precisely the Income Support structure: an employment track as the default, a

medical-exemption track as the exception you must prove your way into.

Alberta's Income Support model (existing)	AISH → ADAP (now)
Sorts every client by employability into two streams: Expected to Work and Barriers to Full Employment.	Sorts disability recipients into two tracks: ADAP (employment activation) and a narrowed AISH.
Expected to Work: an employment plan is required; the client is treated as employable.	ADAP: a service navigator initiates employment services — career planning, supported job placements, earnings exemptions.
“Severe Handicap” sub-type is the exception, reserved for those meeting the AISH definition.	AISH becomes the exception: to remain or return, you must re-qualify via the new Disability Income Assistance application.
In the employment stream, failing to follow the employment plan can lead a worker to deny or end benefits.	Built on the same model — employment-activation expectations, with inability at risk of being read as non-compliance.
Categorization is dynamic: a worker revises the client's sub-type as their labour-market relationship changes.	The same re-sorting logic — which is why “they’ll change the AISH criteria” is structurally, not just anecdotally, true.

A note on the right-hand column: the items describing ADAP's employment apparatus and the re-qualification requirement are documented in the government's transition correspondence. The conditionality — inability being read as non-compliance — is documented in the Income Support model ADAP mirrors; whether the new unified General Regulation (Alberta Regulation 96/2026, in force July 2, 2026) imports the same penalty in the same words is a question worth confirming against that regulation's text. The architecture it copies, however, is built on it.

The contradiction at the centre

AISH eligibility is defined by the government's own standard: a severe disability that permanently limits a person's ability to earn a livelihood. By definition, every person found eligible for AISH was found unable to work. Moving those same people into a program built around employment activation contradicts the very basis on which they were determined eligible. Worse, it imports the conditionality of the employment tier onto a population defined by its inability to meet that tier's expectations. The result is a system in which people who cannot work are placed in a track designed around working, and in which their inability — when it surfaces as a failure to meet employment expectations — is at risk of being recorded as non-compliance. The vocabulary of choice and empowerment in the program's materials conceals a sorting mechanism, not a menu of options.

The government's own correspondence states the contradiction in a single breath. Its May 12, 2026 letter to recipients kept on AISH sets the AISH employment exemption for single clients at \$350 per month, and says this “reflects the AISH program's focus on supporting individuals with severe and permanent disabilities who are unable to work.” That is the government conceding, in writing, that people it describes as “unable to work” are nonetheless expected to earn some employment income — enough to require an exemption for it. “Unable to work” does not mean “earns nothing.” Which is why employment earnings cannot logically serve as the criterion that sorts a person out of AISH and onto an employment-activation track: the program itself exempts the very earnings it would otherwise treat as evidence of employability.

The deferred cut

The financial design reinforces the welfare-to-work logic. ADAP's base monthly living allowance is set at \$1,740 — below the current AISH living allowance of \$1,940, a reduction of \$200 per month. A temporary transition benefit of \$200 a month bridges that exact gap, holding recipients at the \$1,940 level only until December 31, 2027. After that date the bridge expires and the lower base rate stands alone. The same design narrows the room to earn: the employment earnings exemption — the amount a person may earn before benefits are reduced — falls from the current AISH level of \$1,072 per month to \$350 on AISH or \$700 on ADAP. So the program lowers the floor and tightens the earnings allowance at the same time. The model's implicit answer to that reduction is employment income: the recipient is expected to make up the difference by working. This is the founding premise of welfare-to-work — that assistance is a floor people should work their way off of — applied to a population the program's own eligibility rules describe as permanently unable to do so. The transition benefit is not a raise. It is a placeholder with an expiry date, and the cut it postpones arrives in 2028.

Why “they’ll change the criteria” is structurally true

A recurring fear in the disability community is that the criteria for AISH will be changed. The architecture explains why that fear is well-founded rather than merely anxious. In the Income Support model, client categorization is explicitly dynamic: sub-types are revised as a person's relationship to the labour market is reassessed. Imported onto disability income, this means a recipient's tier is not settled. The same machinery that sorts a person into ADAP or AISH can re-sort them later. A system built to tier people by employability is, by design, a system built to re-tier them — and the criteria that govern the tiers are the most natural lever to adjust.

Conclusion

ADAP is welfare-to-work for disabled Albertans. The documented record — Alberta's existing Income Support employability tiers, the conditionality that governs the employment track, and ADAP's own employment-activation design — describes a single machine, now extended to a population it was never built for. The program's language speaks of choice, empowerment, and the highest core benefit in the country. Its architecture speaks of sorting, conditionality, and a floor people are expected to work their way off. Laid side by side, the structure tells the truer story — and it is the structure, not the language, that will govern people's lives.

Sources

Alberta Income and Employment Supports Policy Manual — client categorization, Expected to Work and Barriers to Full Employment streams, and dynamic sub-type assignment. Alberta Works Income Support client sub-types — “Medical or Multiple Barriers” and “Severe Handicap.” Government of Alberta ADAP transition correspondence, May 2026, including the May 12, 2026 “remain on AISH” letter (\$350 employment exemption; “unable to work” language) and the ADAP-transition letter (service-navigator apparatus; \$1,740 base allowance; \$200 transition benefit to December 31, 2027; Disability Income Assistance application). Government of Alberta ADAP Fact Sheet and program page (ADAP base \$1,740; ADAP exemption \$700; AISH base \$1,940; current AISH exemption \$1,072). Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped General Regulation, Alberta Regulation 96/2026 (unified AISH/ADAP regulation, in force July 2, 2026). Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped Act — eligibility standard (severe disability permanently limiting ability to earn a livelihood).

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